India–Maldives:
“Strengthening Ties, Unlocking Potential.

Confidential and Proprietory

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FOREWORD

The Maldives occupies a distinctive position within the Indian Ocean and South Asian economic landscape. As an archipelagic nation located along important maritime routes, the country combines globally recognised tourism assets with a strong fisheries tradition, an increasingly important services economy, and significant potential in the blue economy, renewable energy, digital services and climate-resilient infrastructure. Its extensive marine resources, strategic location, growing connectivity and close links with regional economies create meaningful opportunities for international business cooperation. At the same time, the country's dispersed geography, limited land availability, high logistics costs, dependence on imports and tourism, climate vulnerability, freshwater constraints and relatively small domestic market shape the operating environment for businesses and investors.

India and Maldives share a longstanding relationship encompassing diplomatic, economic, development, commercial and people-to-people ties. India was among the first countries to recognise Maldives after its independence in 1965, and bilateral relations have developed across areas including infrastructure, healthcare, education, capacity building, connectivity, tourism, trade, digital cooperation and development assistance. Bilateral trade has expanded over time, with India supplying a wide range of essential goods, food products, construction materials, pharmaceuticals, machinery and other products to the Maldivian market, while opportunities exist to further strengthen cooperation in fisheries, tourism, infrastructure, renewable energy, healthcare, logistics, technology and other emerging sectors.

Looking ahead, this Knowledge Paper outlines a practical framework through which CCI India can contribute to strengthening India–Maldives economic and commercial engagement. The focus is not limited to conventional trade promotion, but extends towards structured business matchmaking, sector-specific market intelligence, startup and SME cooperation, technology partnerships, investment facilitation and sustained institutional dialogue. CCI India can potentially work with the Embassy of India in Maldives, relevant Maldivian ministries and agencies, chambers of commerce, business associations, tourism and fisheries stakeholders, financial institutions, startups and private-sector organisations to identify and develop commercially viable opportunities.

The objective is to serve as a reference for CCI India's dialogue with Maldivian institutions, industry stakeholders, investors, entrepreneurs and Indian companies seeking to understand and participate in the Maldivian market, while contributing to a stronger, more diversified and sustainable India–Maldives business ecosystem.



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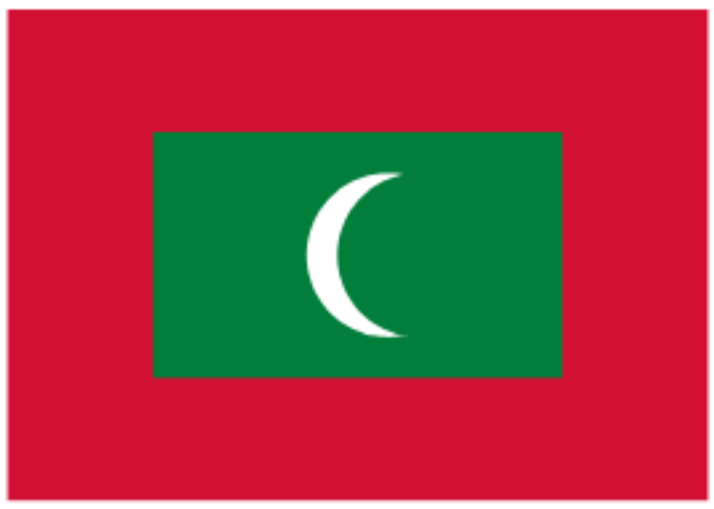
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MALDIVES

> Drift slowly through turquoise waters—beauty unfolds with every moment. Budget travel brings you closer to island life and gentle hospitality.



Basic Facts and Economic Overview

The Republic of Maldives is an archipelago nation located in the Indian Ocean, known for its low-lying atolls. The capital is Malé. The official currency is the Maldivian Rufiyaa (MVR). According to 2024 estimates, the country has a small but rapidly growing population of approximately 601,269.

The Maldivian economy is highly specialized and is fundamentally driven by its tourism sector, which contributes approximately 30% of the Gross Domestic Product (GDP) and accounts for over 60% of foreign exchange receipts. The second major sector is fishing (primarily tuna), followed by related industries like shipping and boat building. Agriculture and manufacturing play minor roles due to limited land and labour availability. For the year 2024, the estimated Nominal GDP stands at around $7.05 billion, with a robust estimated real GDP growth of 3.5% (World Bank projection), driven primarily by record-high tourist arrivals .

Bilateral Trade with India:

India and the Maldives has seen steady growth, though it remains a modest figure in a global context. The total bilateral merchandise trade in 2024 stood at approximately $593.24 Million (or $0.59 Billion).India continues to be one of the Maldives' key trading partners, primarily exporting essential commodities such as food products, construction materials, medicines, and petroleum products. In contrast, imports from the Maldives to India remain limited, largely consisting of marine products like fish. The trade relationship is further strengthened by India's role in supporting the Maldives' economic stability through concessional lines of credit, infrastructure development projects, and capacity-building initiatives, contributing to a balanced and mutually beneficial partnership



Culture and Heritage

For more than 2,500 years, India and Sri Lanka have been connected through shared culture, faith, and language. Buddhism is a key bond, along with Hindu and Tamil traditions. Modern travel links and strong visitor flows keep this relationship vibrant.

India's Exports to Maldives :

India is a major supplier of goods to the Maldives, ranking as the third-largest supplier of imports to the Maldives globally (at around 13.8% of total Maldivian imports in 2024). This is a critical lifeline, cemented by the renewal of the essential commodities trade agreement.



Key Players in Imports from India (2024):
The top categories driving imports from India are broadly related to construction, food security, and healthcare:

- Salt, Sulphur, Earth, Stone, Plaster, Lime, and Cement
- Iron and Steel (Construction materials).
- Machinery, Nuclear Reactors, Boilers .
- Electrical, Electronic Equipment.
- Edible Vegetables and Certain Roots/Tubers & Cereals.



Key Players in Exports to India (2024):

The export profile is highly concentrated and often volatile, suggesting reliance on specialized transactions.

- Aircraft, Spacecraft
- Iron and Steel
- Copper
- Aluminum

Maldives' major global export is Fish Products, which accounts for almost the entirety of its total goods exports globally. While India allows duty-free tuna exports from the Maldives, this product did not feature prominently in the 2024 top imports from the Maldives, which were dominated by the single, high-value Aircraft/Spacecraft category.

Executive Summary

The Maldives is a small, upper-middle-income island economy of about 515,000 residents (census 2022) spread across roughly 190 inhabited islands. Its nominal GDP was about US$7.7 billion in 2025. Tourism drives growth, government revenue and foreign-exchange earnings. That concentration produced a strong 2025, when the World Bank estimates real growth of 6.3% and arrivals reached a record 2.25 million. It also produced a sharp reversal in 2026, when the Middle East conflict disrupted flights and pushed the World Bank's 2026 growth projection down to 0.7%.

The public finances are the main macroeconomic constraint. Public and publicly guaranteed debt stood at 126.9% of GDP in mid-2025. In April 2026 the government repaid a US$500 million sovereign sukuk and a US$400 million currency swap with the Reserve Bank of India. Reserves fell from about US$1.3 billion in March 2026 to about US$718 million in April and US$643.8 million by end-August. Fitch upgraded the sovereign rating in June 2026, but the rating remains deeply speculative.

India is the Maldives' second-largest trading partner according to India's Ministry of Commerce. Bilateral merchandise trade was US$771.76 million in FY2025-26, up 13.54% from US$679.70 million in FY2024-25. Indian exports were US$458.71 million and imports from the Maldives about US$313 million. Indian exports are mainly essential commodities, construction inputs, pharmaceuticals and engineering goods. The Maldivian side reports lower import values from India than India reports as exports, a gap explained in Part 4.

India-financed infrastructure, including the Greater Malé Connectivity Project and Hanimaadhoo Airport, is the most visible commercial footprint.

Where the opportunities are

- **Food, essential goods and cold chain**, driven by near-total import dependence for food and Indian quota arrangements.
- **Construction and infrastructure services**, supported by Indian financing and by Indian contractors already active in the country.
- **Healthcare and pharmaceuticals**, given India's existing export base and the 2025 pharmacopoeia cooperation MoU.
- **Fisheries and blue economy**, where a 2025 MoU on fisheries and aquaculture creates a framework and the sector is undergoing reform.
- **Digital payments and fintech**, following RuPay and Favara–UPI.
- **Tourism-linked services**, as India is a large but not leading source market (sixth in 2025).

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1. Country Profile of Maldives

1.1 Country at a Glance

Indicator	Value
Total resident population	515,132 (382,639 Maldivians; 132,493 resident foreigners)
Foreign share of residents	About 26%, roughly 1 in 4 residents
Population location	Malé area 41%; administrative islands 46%; resorts 10%; industrial islands 3%
Nominal GDP	US$7.74 billion
GDP per capita (nominal)	About US$14,600
Real GDP growth	6.3% (2025 estimate); 3.5% (2024)
Real GDP growth, 2026	0.7% (WB), 1.0% (ADB, IMF)
Tourist arrivals	2.25 million in 2025 (+9.8%)
Public and publicly guaranteed debt	US$9.5 billion, 126.9% of GDP
Official reserves	US$643.8 million (end-August 2026)
Sovereign rating (Fitch)	Upgraded June 2026 to the CCC category (reported as CCC- by one source, CCC by another)
Merchandise exports (2023)	Fish and fish products dominate; unprocessed tuna about two thirds of merchandise export earnings
Bilateral trade with India	US$771.76 million, FY2025-26

1.2 Geography and Maritime Setting

The Maldives is a chain of coral islands in the central Indian Ocean, south-west of India and Sri Lanka. Sources differ on the number of islands and atolls because of geographic versus administrative classifications. The 2022 census enumerated 187 inhabited islands. The paper uses “about 190 inhabited islands” as a working figure.

The land area is very small, but the Exclusive Economic Zone is large. The country's small islands, low elevation and dispersed settlement drive most of its structural business challenges: high per-unit costs for transport, power, water and waste, and difficulty achieving scale outside the Greater Malé area. The census itself describes the Maldives as one of the most spread-out countries in the world.

1.3 Population and Demographics

The 2022 census counted 515,132 residents, of whom 382,639 were resident Maldivians and 132,493 resident foreigners. About 41% of residents live in the Malé area (Malé, Hulhumalé, Vilimalé and Hulhulé), 46% in administrative islands, 10% in resorts and 3% on industrial islands. The working-age population (15 and over) is 411,219, or 80% of residents; 63% of working-age residents are men and 37% women, and 68% are Maldivians while 32% are foreigners. The census counted 94,424 households.

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